

Time Empire or: The Absolute Certainty of Reality

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Synopsis: Amidst an unexplainable pandemic, an ailing detective investigates the mysterious disappearance of a woman and her daughter.

Characters:

- The Detective
- Lydia Emerald
- Nora Emerald
- Frank Emerald
- Mike Sullivan
- The Wardens
- The Professor
- The Hypnotist

Plot:

*Scenes shot in **color** will be written in dark magenta. Scenes shot in **sepia** will be written in dark orange. The rest will be in **black and white**.*

Prologue

Far into the night, in a dark and grimy industrial city, something unnatural unfolds in Apartment 101. Inside, a cacophony of light, heartbeats and a swirling fog produces a human body from nothingness. At first, a heart manifests itself, followed by a brain, blood vessels, nerves, and bones knitting themselves into a skeleton. Organs and tissues then bloom one after another before finally arriving at the skin. But as the skin envelops the body, its creation is interrupted. The eyes of the heavily deformed man snap wide open and he lets out a spine-chilling scream, agonizing from the pain of his incomplete creation. Naked and trembling, he staggers out of bed and trudges out of the apartment block, wailing through the dimly lit streets before collapsing and falling unconscious, miles away from the apartment block. This man will become The Detective.

Part 1 - The Detective

The Detective, wearing a mask and gloves to hide his deformity, wakes up in a gargantuan castle hiding within a mountainous landscape. Inside a scrumptious dining room, he finds himself tied to a chair and facing a game of chess, laid on the table before him. The Hypnotist, a seemingly ordinary man dressed in a business suit, enters the room. The Detective pleads for answers: Why is he imprisoned here? What does The Hypnotist want from him? The Hypnotist ignores him. He simply gestures to the chessboard and says, “Checkmate.”

The Detective is unable to recall ever playing this game and The Hypnotist is fully aware of that. He describes the checkmate as an effect without a cause and for the effect to remain real, the cause needs to happen. The board suddenly vanishes into thin air. Confused and exasperated, The Detective is at his wits end. The Hypnotist reveals he did “edit” reality to include a fabricated scene of them playing the game but the edit was rejected and the board disappeared, as if it never existed. He explains that this is the direct result of The Detective failing to remember the game, since it never happened. Hence, due to the strange unconscious influence the human mind exerts over reality, the fake scene couldn’t be assimilated as real.

The Hypnotist tries to remove The Detective’s mask but he begs him not to, saying he is embarrassed of what’s under it. The Hypnotist respects his plea and reveals he knows why The Detective never removes the mask; it’s not there to hide his disfigurement but to hide the darker facades of his personality. Suddenly, a scream is heard, echoing from a nearby room. It scares The Detective but piques his curiosity.

Nine months after his interrupted creation in Apartment 101, The Detective now resides in the basement of a convenience store. Its owner, Ronald, is a kind-hearted old man who rescued him from the freezing streets and helped him recover by sheltering and feeding him. In a conversation with his therapist, The Detective recounts how when he emerged into existence, he possessed all the faculties of a fully grown man but he was amnesic, void of any memories or knowledge of his origins. He tried to investigate how he had been born from nothing and why his body was so severely deformed, but with no recollection of Apartment 101 or its surroundings, his search led to a dead end. All he could remember was his painful birth, followed by a blank on what happened afterwards, and then waking up after losing consciousness on the street. Over time, he realized he had a gift for deduction and reasoning. With Ronald’s help, he set up a private investigator’s office in the basement where he began solving small-time cases, mostly petty thefts and extramarital affairs. He did what he could to repay Ronald for everything he’s done for him.

As the session nears its end, The Detective reveals he seems to recollect a vague memory from his childhood, which is strange considering he was born a fully grown man. *In this memory, he remembers snatching a porcelain doll from a little girl and throwing it down a sewage tunnel out of mischief. Through the opened manhole, the sight of the doll’s cracked face sends the girl bursting into tears. Though a sense of regret stirred within him, he remembers remaining cold and detached from the girl’s cries.* Also, he often experiences a dream of being inside an abandoned radio station, called *The Golden Reverb*, where the song “Blue Moon” (Elvis Presley version) plays perpetually on a record player.

A few days later, The Detective delivers a set of photographs to a distraught client, showing the man’s wife sleeping with another guy in a shabby motel. The man sobs uncontrollably and The Detective stands there awkwardly, unsure of what to say. Around noon, he returns to the convenience store where Ronald informs him that a letter arrived earlier this morning. It was addressed specifically to The Detective but the sender’s anonymous. Ronald placed it in The Detective’s basement office and just as he’s about to head downstairs, Ronald asks him a strange question, “Where did you get the inspiration for your mask?” The Detective, confused, points out that Ronald knows very well the mask was homemade and crudely cobbled together by

The Detective himself. Yet, Ronald affirms he has seen it before. He suddenly seems to remember having seen someone wearing that exact same mask decades ago, although this memory seems fuzzy and without any clear context.

In the basement, The Detective opens the letter and finds some cash and a polaroid photograph of a woman and a young girl, presumably the woman's daughter. On the back, two names are scrawled in shaky handwriting: "Lydia and Nora Emerald." Just then, his phone rings. An eerie modulated voice on the other hand simply says, "This is your down payment. Find them and your reward will be considerable." Before he can respond, the line goes dead. Perplexed but curious, The Detective stares at the photograph, conflicted on whether to take the case or not. This case is unlike anything he's ever handled before, far beyond the petty matters he's grown used to. To make things worse, his illness is growing more aggressive, steadily making him lose his strengths.

All around the globe, a mysterious and deadly pandemic plagues nearly half of the world's population. Those afflicted suffer from persistent headaches, frequent nausea and vomiting, along with a growing sense of spatial and temporal disorientation. The disease's progression varies from person to person but it almost always results in certain death. In its final stages, the illness causes severe physical disfigurement, with dark, scaly patches spreading through the skin and tumors swelling all over the body. As the grotesque final transformation is complete, death quickly follows. Attempts to understand the disease have failed. It is most certainly not contagious and isn't caused by any pathogens. There is also no evidence linking it to genetics or environmental factors. Despite the global scale of its spread, the cause of this illness defies all medical explanations.

The Detective climbs out of the basement and although it's been only half an hour since he returned to the store, it is now night. The store is closed and at the counter, instead of Ronald, a young man is rifling through the cash register. Startled, the man recoils at the sight of The Detective. Mistaking him for a robber, the man panics, grabs a shotgun from under the counter and aims it at The Detective. The Detective raises his hands and insists there must be a misunderstanding. He asks where Ronald is. The young man freezes, and replies, "I am Ronald." The Detective remains speechless. The tension peaks and just as the young man is about to pull the trigger, The Detective swiftly bolts down the stairs and slams the basement door behind him, heart pounding. Moments later, he cautiously opens the door only to find that it's noon again and the familiar old Ronald is back at the register, oblivious to what just happened.

The Detective regains his composure and quietly leaves the store, still trying to process this experience. He doesn't speak a word of what just happened, knowing how absurd it would sound. He drives to the police headquarters to obtain some leads for his case. A police lieutenant, who had previously worked on Lydia's and Nora's disappearance, reveals Lydia was married to Frank Emerald and they were both affiliated with the Holloway Syndicate, a criminal organization tightening its grip on the city from the shadows. He reveals that 9 months ago, Lydia shot Frank dead and vanished with their 8 years old daughter, Nora. Fingerprints taken at the scene confirm Lydia's culpability but attempts to find her were fruitless. Knowing the syndicate prefers to handle their own problems without police interference, the authorities quietly abandoned the case out of fear. Before The Detective heads out, the lieutenant reveals one peculiar detail about the murder; when the officers

found Frank's body, his brain had been surgically removed. Unbeknownst to them, a corrupt police officer has been eavesdropping their conversation. He makes a phone call and informs whoever is on the other hand that someone else is also looking for Lydia.

After leaving the building, The Detective sits down at a bar to process what he has learned, whilst sipping on a glass of whisky. It's clear this isn't a simple case of marital dispute erupting into a crime of passion. Frank's brain being taken away and the strange coincidence of the murder occurring 9 months ago, right around the time he was "born", is perplexing to say the least. There seems to be no reasonable explanation for why these two events could be interlinked. But the fact that he was chosen for this investigation, whilst there are dozens of more experienced private investigators specializing in these cases all over the city, convinces him that there must be a personal connection between him and this affair.

Whilst deep in contemplation, a man approaches The Detective's table, introducing himself as Mike Sullivan. He looks perturbed and irritated, barely trying to conceal his frustrations. Without beating around the bush, he states that he knows The Detective is searching for Lydia, just like he has been doing since her disappearance. He recounts how Frank was his childhood friend, a man who always stood up for him and saved his life countless of times during their sanguinary assignments for the Holloway Syndicate. To him, Frank was more than a friend; he was also an indispensable member of the syndicate. He leans closer to The Detective, trying to intimidate him into handing over Lydia's location if he manages to find her first.

But The Detective knows Mike is out for revenge, so he bluntly and fearlessly refuses. Mike, his intimidation attempts having failed, tries to pull on The Detective's heartstrings> He reveals a secret he's been carrying for years: Nora isn't Frank's daughter, she's his. Frank never knew this and Mike never told him, fearing the truth would only hurt him. The fact that Lydia ran away with Nora just added salt to the injury after losing Frank. Calming his tone, Mike insists he won't harm Lydia, he just wants to reunite with his daughter. But The Detective is unconvinced, sensing Mike's lust for vengeance. He quickly gulps down his drink and leaves the table, refusing to entertain Mike's manipulations. As he nears the door, Mike, in a cold and menacing tone, tells him he knows where his office is and if he doesn't cooperate, Ronald will pay the price. The Detective, disturbed, simply leaves without uttering a word.

Mike stays behind, ordering a bottle of vodka to numb his emotions. Barely an hour later, he's already plastered. As he looks at the bar counter, he finds something extremely baffling. **Frank's there**, hurriedly enjoying a drink. Mike couldn't believe his eyes. Is this just a drunken hallucination? He walks to him, stumbling along the way, and Frank greets him with open arms before congratulating him for his wedding last Saturday. Mike is beyond confused. What wedding? He is definitely not married. What is he talking about? Before he can ask any questions, Frank quickly grabs his coat and leaves, apologizing to Mike for not being present at his wedding since he had an assignment out of the city. Mike chases him but just as Frank exits the door, he vanishes into thin air. He looks around the streets, Frank's nowhere to be found.

Discarding this experience as a result of his inebriation, Mike jumps into his car and drives away, unaware that The Detective is tailing him from a distance. He follows Mike to an apartment block and watches him as he

climbs the stairs to a hallway where he enters his apartment, which turns out to be Apartment 101. A strange feeling married to a wave of nausea and disorientation befalls The Detective as he nears Mike's apartment. He seems to recall this place but the roots of this familiarity escapes him. He remains hidden in the gloomy hallway, patiently waiting for an opportunity to get inside. After a while, Mike leaves and locks the door behind him. Once gone, The Detective picks the lock and slips inside.

On the surface it seems like a normal two bedroom apartment, albeit in a slightly disorganized and grimy state. There are two offices, he goes inside one and rummages through the drawers where he stumbles on a bunch of papers, including a few bank statements with Lydia's name. However, her full name is listed as Lydia Anderson. Could she have been here? Yet something is off, the bank statements are from 10 years ago. Who keeps bank statements from such a long time ago? He takes some pictures of the papers, having a hunch that they could prove useful in his investigations. Just then, the door creaks open. The Detective quickly bolts behind a wall, gun drawn, in case things go south. The person lights up the hearth but then senses that someone's inside the apartment. "Come out now," a female voice commands. The Detective hesitantly turns to see who that person is and inconceivably, it's Lydia, the same Lydia he has been tasked to find.

With a gun pointed straight at him, Lydia orders The Detective to drop his weapon. The Detective complies and pleads for answers, asking where she's been and if she and her daughter are okay. Lydia, very confused, says she's always been living here and most definitely never had a daughter. The Detective's confusion reaches its peak. None of what he has experienced lately is making any sense. Before he can press for more answers, Lydia cocks her pistol and forces The Detective out of the apartment, saying when her husband returns, he won't be as forgiving as her. She assumes The Detective is just another private investigator hired to meddle in her affairs linked to the Holloway Syndicate. After The Detective exits the apartment, Lydia slams the door shut and locks it. In her office, she finds her bank statements scattered across her desk. Alarmed, she swiftly grabs them and throws them into the fireplace.

Outside, The Detective refuses to let go. If Nora is in danger, he can't just leave. He pulls a backup pistol from his ankle holster and breaks open the door. But inside, Lydia is now inexplicably gone. The layout of the apartment is somehow completely different from how it was mere minutes ago. The second bedroom has now been repurposed into a storage room and the second office is now just an empty room with no furniture whatsoever. He carefully goes through every inch of the apartment and finds nothing useful at all. Hearing footsteps echoing down the hallway, he quickly dashes out through the fire exit. Mike, carrying a bag of liquor, sees the broken door and doesn't need to guess who was responsible.

As The Detective drives back to his office, he finds a black sedan racing past him in the opposite lane. Inside, he glances at something utterly mystifying; he finds a **perfect double of himself**, same mask, same coat, same hat, thrashing wildly inside the vehicle whilst four indistinguishable figures struggle to restrain him. Feeling like he's on the verge of losing his sanity, he performs a sharp U-turn and chases the mysterious black car. But he quickly loses track of it, lost in the maze of city streets. Shaken, he pulls over and takes a deep breath to regain his equanimity. What the hell is happening?

Back in his office, The Detective examines the pictures taken at Apartment 101, scrutinizing each and every detail until something odd about Lydia's bank statements catches his eye. Almost all of her transactions involve parties from within the city, except for one. It seems Lydia transferred a substantial sum to a certain Samantha Anderson, whose address points to a remote village far beyond the city. Wasting no time, he rushes out of the basement and steps into the convenience store. But there, he freezes when he finds Mike standing casually beside Ronald at the cash register.

Mike coldly reminds The Detective of what would happen if he refuses to cooperate but The Detective's stance remains unchanged. Realizing it's useless to try and reason with him, Mike draws his gun and aims it at Ronald, who stands frozen in panic, confused and terrified. Without hesitation, The Detective pulls his weapon and fires at Mike, grazing his shoulders. Mike retaliates, injuring The Detective, and a chaotic gunfight ensues. Bullets tear through the store, hitting innocent customers caught in the crossfire. The Detective grabs Ronald and shoves him into his car before speeding away. It's too late for Mike to give chase so he storms into the basement, rummages through The Detective's stuff, and stumbles on his pictures of Apartment 101. He grabs them and bolts out before the arrival of the police.

The Detective, bleeding from the arm, races through the city and drops Ronald at a train station, imploring him to grab the next train heading out of the city. He escorts him to the train, making sure he hasn't been followed, and apologizes vehemently for bringing trouble into his life. But Ronald understands he was only doing his job. He urges The Detective to go to a hospital for his gunshot wounds but he refuses, stubborn as always. With one final nod, Ronald wishes him good luck before The Detective limps back to his car and speeds off into the distance, hell-bent on finding some answers to this case and all the inexplicable events he has been experiencing. Unbeknownst to him, a strange faceless man, wearing a suit, a hat and some kind of jet black tissue covering the entirety of his head, has discreetly put a tracker under his car.

At The Hypnotist's castle, The Detective unsuccessfully attempts to break free from his restraints. The Hypnotist reveals that the only reason he hasn't killed The Detective yet is because he wants to understand why he even exists. To make him grasp what's really going on, The Hypnotist starts by explaining the **philosophy of idealism**, the idea that the nature of reality is, in one way or another, rooted in the mind. Initially, he believed in **subjective idealism**, which states that reality is entirely a mental construct, as argued by George Berkeley. It posits that only the mind exists, reality is immaterial, and an object comes into existence only when perceived. But he realized that the fabric of reality was much more complicated than this. It can only be explained by merging 2 types of idealist systems: **Absolute Idealism** and **Transcendental Idealism**. Seeing that The Detective is quickly losing interest in his ramblings, The Hypnotist locks eyes with him, leans to him, and asks, "If you could rectify your worst mistake, what would it be?"

Now well past midnight, after hours of driving, The Detective finally reaches the isolated village which stood out in Lydia's bank statements. Samantha's address leads to an old dilapidated house, which seems empty at first glance. Gun drawn, The Detective slowly makes his way inside, the door having been kept unlocked. In the dim living room, sitting in front of the TV, a bald elderly woman sips on a cup filled with liquor, while watching a

soap opera rerun. She glances at The Detective and nonchalantly asks if he's come to kill her. The Detective quickly lowers his weapon and tells her he's only here for answers and won't reveal her location to anyone, not even the unknown person who hired him. He came to this decision after realizing that the police can't be trusted as long as Mike, along with the syndicate, is out there to kill her and avenge Frank's death.

The old woman introduces herself as Samantha Anderson, Lydia's mother. She reveals that Lydia had called her this afternoon from an untraceable number, after she got into trouble with her husband, Frank. She said she would be returning to her childhood home, bringing Nora with her, knowing neither Frank nor the syndicate are aware that this place exists. The Detective's blood runs cold as he processes the implications of what this means. Is he somehow back in time? He connects the dots and concludes he is now back to 9 months ago, during the night of Frank's murder. This means Lydia and her daughter will be here soon, to hide from the police and more importantly, the syndicate.

Samantha laments her daughter's life choices. She always knew Lydia hated the poverty they grew up in and instead of earning her way out of it earnestly, she got affiliated with the wrong people and became entangled with the mob. Their relationship grew distant but Samantha had promised to her daughter that if she ever found herself in trouble, she could always return home. Lydia kept sending her money but Samantha never touched a cent, knowing very well it was blood money. But Lydia never failed to send her mother monthly allowances, which has been piling up in her account for years now. Despite now dying from metastatic breast cancer, Samantha still refuses to use the money to pay for her treatment, resolutely saying that she's lived enough and is ready to face death. Her life has always been marred with disappointment and solitude so she sees no point in trying to extend her misery.

The Detective describes some distant headlights quickly approaching the house. He bolts outside to see who it is. But the moment he steps out, the world shifts and it is now inexplicably daytime. The incoming vehicle is gone and when he turns to get back inside, the door is now locked. He assumes it's another temporal jump and now weary of everything that has transpired lately, he unhesitantly breaks open the door and storms through the rooms until he finally finds Lydia, sitting on the same couch he found her mother sitting on 9 months ago, which for him was mere minutes ago.

She shifts her gaze to him and says, "I recognize you." Having seen The Detective 10 years ago in Apartment 101, she never quite forgot him due to his distinctive mask. She reveals Samantha passed away around 4 months ago and she had been bracing herself for the day the syndicate would eventually come knocking at her door. But The Detective assures her he's not one of them; he's just in search of answers. When he asks where Nora is, Lydia gestures to the backyard, where two wooden crosses stand side by side: one for her mother and one for her 8 years old daughter, where they were both buried. She then proceeds to recount the fateful night that led to the death of Frank and ultimately, her daughter Nora:

In a **flashback**, Frank returns home earlier than usual, his mood visibly gloomy. He shuts himself in his room, retrieves a bottle of whiskey from his drawer, and drinks profusely. A few moments later, he bursts out and unexpectedly lashes out at Lydia, blaming her for being unfaithful and cheating on him with Mike Sullivan, who

is revealed to be Lydia's ex-husband. Though she was always aware Frank struggled with alcoholism, he would never become paranoid or violent. He also never accused her of having an affair with Mike before and his sudden onslaught of accusations is extremely baffling to Lydia, who had severed all ties with Mike since their divorce 8 years ago. But Frank is relentless, consumed by a delusion that's progressively feeding his anger and paranoia. Their argument escalates and turns physical when Frank abruptly punches her, shattering her nose. Bloodied and traumatized, she swiftly stumbles up the stairs and locks herself in her bedroom, before calling Samantha to plan an escape. But to her dismay, she remembers that her gun is still in her car, parked outside.

As the night falls, Lydia can hear Frank's outbursts echoing through the walls, hearing him smashing furniture and tableware. She crouches by the door, waiting for a moment when she can grab Nora and flee. But suddenly, an eerie silence settles in. Hoping Frank went outside to simmer down, she prepares to leave. Just to be sure, she peers through her keyhole but alas, her fears proved right. Frank is right in front of the door, silently waiting for her to leave. He begins to plead with her to open the door, his voice rising in desperation. When Lydia doesn't respond, he hurls himself against the door, trying to break it down. Trembling with fear, Lydia considers calling the police but realizes this would only attract unwanted attention to her connection with the syndicate, and they would never forgive her for that. Just as the pounding ceases, screams are heard coming from none other than Nora. Frank, now fully unhinged, threatens to hurt her if she refuses to open the door.

Terrified for her daughter's life, she rushes out and begs him not to hurt Nora, whom Frank is holding tightly in his arms. But Frank screams out how he wants to punish Lydia for cheating on him, despite her persistent reassurances that she never did. It's no use trying to reason with him and just then, with a wicked smile, Frank breaks Nora's neck, right in front of Lydia, who collapses on her knees, too shaken and paralyzed with dread to even scream. Frank mutters that hurting Lydia wouldn't have been enough, so he killed the person she loved most. He then slumps on the floor, humming to himself the lyrics of the song, "Blue Moon", in an extremely inebriated state. Feeling completely numb and dissociated, Lydia catatonically walks to her car, grabs her gun, comes back inside, and unceremoniously unloads bullets after bullets into Frank's chest, all while displaying absolutely no emotion whatsoever. Still in a state of dissociative shock, she lifts Nora's lifeless body in her arms and carries her to the car, before disappearing into the night.

Back to **present**, Lydia's confession sheds light on many of The Detective's questions. Lydia was in Mike's apartment 10 years ago because she was previously married to him. Yet, nothing from Lydia's story accounts for the temporal jumps or the presumed personal connection he has to this case. And if he and Mike are the only ones seemingly looking for Lydia right now, who hired him in the first place? It couldn't have been the syndicate since Mike is already working for them and will stop at nothing to obtain his revenge. Just as he's about to question Lydia further, four men, who all look identical to the faceless man at the train station, silently break into the house. On seeing their shadows stretching across the wall, The Detective briskly pulls his weapon and opens fire. Amidst the chaos, Lydia darts out of the living room, runs into the pantry, and enters a hidden passage leading to the cellar. When The Detective runs out of bullets, the four men, collectively referred to as **The Wardens**, hurl towards him and bind his hands. They search the house but fail to locate Lydia. They quickly retreat outside, dragging their prisoner into a black sedan and driving away.

Hours later, they are back in the city and the story connects to an earlier scene when The Detective, from the past, catches a glimpse of himself inside the sedan, revealing that back then, he had momentarily jumped into the future. He gives chase but the black vehicle quickly manages to evade him. The Wardens drive to a dark alley and forcefully shove The Detective inside a seemingly abandoned store. They march him down a gloomy hallway leading to some kind of hidden laboratory, covered in tangled wires, switches, and a myriad of strange electronic devices. The Detective is strapped to a cold metal table, arms and legs bound, unable to move. He turns to his left and is met with a nightmarish sight: He finds a disembodied brain floating in a vat, submerged in some kind of electrolyte and wired to a huge computer system. Operating the device, we find **The Professor**, who looks like a grotesquely deformed doppelganger of The Hypnotist, perhaps because he is in the final stages of the inexplicable disease sweeping across the world.

The Professor tries to reassure The Detective that he means no harm, he just wants him to see the truth. He claims there's a destructive being out there who is hell-bent on trying to break the rules of reality and he now needs to rectify the catastrophe that has been unleashed by this person. The Professor picks up a helmet-like device, laced with cables linked to the computer system, which is in turn wired to the brain in the vat. He forces it onto The Detective's head, who is still thrashing against his restraints, trying to break free. The Professor activates the switch and The Detective's consciousness is precipitated into a Stygian abyss.

For a brief instant, there's only darkness until a blurry image materializes. The image gradually sharpens and becomes more discernible. The Detective realizes he's no longer in his own body but in a person's mind, perhaps a memory. Experiencing that person's point of view, he finds himself inside a house, standing over Lydia, bloodied and unconscious on the floor. He checks her pulse and confirms she's still alive. He desperately tries to wake her up, when suddenly, a voice cuts through the room, "Look Frank, you have to come with me." He turns to the voice and finds Mike, with a stupefied look on his face, slowly walking towards him. The Detective realizes he's inside Frank's memory. He has no control over his actions, being merely a passive observer to this memory. Frank, rattled and confused, assumes Mike is the one who attacked Lydia. He frantically searches for Nora but Mike lunges at him, trying to subdue him with a chloroform-soaked cloth. But Frank draws his gun and whilst they brawl for the weapon, The Detective is suddenly yanked out of the memory.

He wakes up back in the laboratory only to be caught in the midst of a fierce shootout between The Hypnotist and The Wardens. Bullets rip through the air as The Hypnotist successfully guns down all four of them but strangely, when the bullets hit them, their bodies shatter like brittle glass, with not a single drop of blood spilled. During the battle, The Professor manages to slip a printed photograph in The Detective's coat, unnoticed in the chaos. Finally, The Hypnotist fires at the vat, obliterating Frank's brain, which was being partially preserved inside. The Detective, stunned and utterly confused, craves to understand what's going on. But The Hypnotist tells him not to worry since he'll soon forget it all. He grabs a syringe and stabs The Detective in the neck, pumping into his veins a sedative which immediately renders him unconscious.

Inside an endless white void, referred to as **Void A**, The Hypnotist approaches what looks like a strange flatbed editing machine, which seems to fuse unknown technologies, along with cryptic symbols etched into the

dashboard. Before the machine stands a large silver screen and these two items constitute the only objects in Void A. The Hypnotist operates the machine and on the screen, the **events of the story** are projected, from the moment The Detective woke up on the day he received the anonymous letter up to the laboratory gunfight. These events spanned a total of 48 hours. He turns a dial and projects events which happened even further back in time, to the night of Frank's and Nora's murder. The scene starts off just as Lydia described it, with Frank drunk and lashing out on her. But then, the footage becomes fuzzier and some continuity errors become flagrantly obvious. The perpetrator alternates between Mike and Frank, and it becomes unclear who actually hit Lydia and killed Nora. The Hypnotist, gradually becoming more distraught, rewinds back to the beginning of the scene once more, but this time, Frank didn't even return home that afternoon. Yet, he is present when he punches Lydia but disappears again when he grabs Nora, having been replaced by Mike, who then mercilessly kills his own daughter. When the replay ends, The Hypnotist mutters under his breath, "Well, fuck."

Somehow back in his basement office, The Detective wakes up with no memories of the last 2 days. He proceeds with his morning ritual: breakfast, a shower and a fleeting moment of normalcy. But once he leaves the basement and steps into the convenience store, he stumbles upon a chaotic scene. There are barricade tapes everywhere, along with shattered selves and bullet holes peppered on the walls and counter. The aftermath of his violent shootout with Mike surrounds him but he has no recollections of it. Even more worryingly, old Ronald is nowhere to be found. He phones the client he is scheduled to meet, aka the distraught husband. The latter, in an understandably puzzled tone, says The Detective already met him. The Detective hangs up, confused and feeling like there's a huge void in his memories.

On the counter lies an envelope addressed to him, with some cash inside, photos of Lydia and Nora Emerald, and finally, a handwritten note with an address in a remote village (Samantha's house). With no recollections of his investigation into Lydia's case, the address and names mean nothing to him. Just then, his phone rings and he sprints back to the basement to answer it. Just like before, the modulated voice says, "This is your down payment. Find them and your reward will be considerable." On the other line, it's finally revealed it was **The Hypnotist who hired The Detective** all along. The Detective notices something in his coat pocket and finds the photograph, the one The Professor had slipped inside. The picture shows Mike loading Lydia's unconscious body into the trunk of a car, right outside Frank's house. The timestamp confirms the picture was taken on the night of Frank's and Nora's murder. But to The Detective, this image, whilst haunting, bears no meaning since he has no memories of Mike. He jumps into his car and begins his long drive towards the address, still disoriented and confused but nevertheless determined to uncover what's happening to him and reclaim whatever was stolen from his mind.

At the castle, The Hypnotist reiterates his question, "If you could rectify your worst mistake, what would it be?" The Detective says his life has been too short to have made any mistake grave enough that's worth correcting. But The Hypnotist says The Detective didn't just materialize into existence from nowhere, something must have triggered his creation. This makes The Detective question if he had a life before and if The Hypnotist wiped his memories, just like he erased the missing 48 hours. The Hypnotist, prideful and conceited, wouldn't miss an opportunity to boast about his accomplishments and yet, he maintains he had nothing to do with The

Detective's existence. Circling back to his question, he reveals that even if someone had the ability to view the past, present and future, they would still have absolutely no power to change anything, bound by the fatalistic nature of reality.

He asserts that free-will is nonexistent and every event, from the beginning of time up to its end, is inevitable. He claims he knows for a fact that the nature of reality is also rooted in **eternalism**, that the past, present and future are all equally real and have already happened. He uses the analogy of a sailing boat traversing a vast ocean: Just because one cannot see beyond the horizon doesn't mean there's nothing there. Time can be likened to the wind pushing the boat but regrettably, it only blows in one direction. However, some individuals can develop the ability to break free from the arrow of time and experience the past, present and future at will. But there's a catch: they can't change anything about it. Ironically, escaping the prison of time's linearity placed them into a newer prison, this one confined by fatalism. For The Hypnotist, this is even worse since despite knowing everything about one's existence, nothing can be changed. A life of despair will still be a life of despair even with the ability to experience every single point in time of one's lifespan. When The Detective asks who possesses such a power, The Hypnotist replies, "Everyone within Time Empire."

Whilst driving through the desolate road leading to the village, The Detective begins to experience nausea and a pounding headache. He pulls over and vomits violently. Right as the headache reaches its peak, ALL his memories of the missing 48 hours crashes into his mind at once. He screams out in agony until the pain finally subsides. He retrieves the photograph The Professor had given him and after remembering what he had seen whilst connected to Frank's brain, it's now crystal clear Mike is the true culprit behind this whole affair, even if some questions still remain unanswered.

The Detective finally arrives at the address. He steps into Lydia's childhood home, gun in his hand, but he's too late. A scene of pure horror stands before him: Lydia's lifeless, naked body lies crumpled on the floor, after having been strangled to death. To add to this revolting sight, he finds that the body shows unmistakable signs of necrophilia. Right behind him, the culprit steps out of the shadows, aiming his weapon at The Detective. It's Mike. He asks The Detective to drop his gun but now deeply shaken and feeling the anger brewing within him, he instead confronts Mike with the truth he's pierced together: **Mike killed Frank and probably killed Nora too.** He staged the crime scene to frame Lydia, planting her fingerprints and making it seem like another tale of domestic violence. Then, he wanted to get rid of Lydia to tie up loose ends. However, some pieces of the puzzle don't fit. Why did Lydia confess to the murder if she didn't do it? And why didn't Mike kill Lydia when he had her? The photograph clearly shows Mike dragging an unconscious Lydia from the crime scene, right after Frank and Nora's murder. So why did he let her go? It didn't add up.

Mike teeters on the edge of a breakdown, bewildered by The Detective's accusations. What is he talking about? He would never have hurt his best friend, let alone kill his own daughter. Through The Detective's words, Mike feels a devastating realization creeping in. Nora is dead. He drops his weapon and collapses on the floor, wailing in despair. This didn't look like a performance, making The Detective question everything. Could he have been wrong? Mike swears he was at home on the night of Frank's murder but The Detective holds up the

photograph. At that instant, Mike's sanity weakens even further. He has absolutely no recollection of this, none at all. He becomes breathless and coughs violently, all while the toll of his distress worsens his health, revealing that he too is suffering from the mysterious disease. The Detective wants to know when he became sick and Mike reveals it all started around 9 months ago, shortly after experiencing a strange dream where he was wandering inside an abandoned radio station, *The Golden Reverb*.

Baffled and overwhelmed, The Detective struggles to make sense of it all. The shared dream and the eerie pattern of everything significant tracing back to 9 months ago, right when he was "born", can no longer be dismissed as coincidences. His eyes fall once more on Lydia's brutalized body and he can no longer contain his anger. He lunges at Mike and quickly overpowers him. He beats him relentlessly as Mike howls in agony. The Detective grabs his gun and presses it against Mike's forehead. Through a pathetic confession, Mike, sobbing uncontrollably, finally admits he deserves to die, saying he knows there's something evil inside him. He expounds how he derives immense pleasure through vengeance, since it's the only way he knows of regaining control and reasserting his ego whenever he is confronted with his own powerlessness. When he feels hurt or threatened, he is consumed by the urge to inflict greater suffering on whoever hurt him. The earliest memory he has of this stems from his childhood. In this memory, after a girl accidentally tripped him while playing, **he threw her beloved porcelain doll down a sewage tunnel.**

A crushing wave of anguish overwhelms The Detective as he realizes he also possesses this memory. Outside, the weather inexplicably worsens. A violent thunderstorm erupts, with lightning flashing across the sky and thunder shaking the ground beneath the village. The health of both The Detective and Mike seem to simultaneously deteriorate within just a few seconds. Then, through some indescribable forces, Mike's body contorts and begins to merge into The Detective, their flesh fusing together in a grotesque **assimilation**. They both shriek in agony from this painful process until Mike is fully absorbed. The Detective collapses on the floor and loses consciousness. The Hypnotist, who has been silently observing the event, approaches The Detective's unconscious body and murmurs to an unseen presence, "Well played, but it's too late."

Part 2 - The Hypnotist

2 years ago, The Professor, then a perfectly healthy and respected lecturer at the city's university, attends a seminar on **hypnotism** hosted by one of his colleagues. The talk explores two competing theories: the **state** theory, which claims hypnotism induces an altered state of consciousness, different from wakefulness and sleep, and the **non-state** theory, which posits hypnosis is merely a result of a combination of normal psychological processes, such as increased focus, imagination and heightened suggestibility. State theorists believe hypnosis can act as a bridge between the conscious and unconscious mind. The Professor, however, dismisses this as pseudoscience. The colleague explains that there might be a multi-level system at play when describing the human mind, echoing **William James'** statement that there could be other forms of consciousness beyond current awareness. The consciousness and the unconscious mind, as well as dreams (sleeping state) might just be levels we are aware of and if the state theory holds, hypnosis might be a gateway to previously undiscovered layers of the mind.

Now intrigued, The Professor raises his hand and asks whether hypnosis could unlock the ability to see the **thing-in-itself**. His colleague smiles, knowing The Professor would come armed with the tougher questions. He explains to his students how the thing-in-itself, according to **Kantian philosophy**, is a state of objects as they exist independently of perception. Kant's idea of **transcendental idealism** describes that space and time do not exist outside of human perception, meaning conscious minds do not view reality in its true form, but only as it appears to us. This implies that the nature of reality is inherently **subjective** to humans. Extending this idea, the colleague evokes the philosophy of **absolute idealism** (initially proposed by G. W. F. Hegel), where true reality is one single all-encompassing consciousness, referred to as **The Absolute**. If this is true, it means everything is part of an all-inclusive whole, including the subjects (minds) and the objects (the material world).

The colleague eventually concedes that the idea of hypnosis, as it's currently being practised, being capable of breaking the illusion of time and space is incredibly far-fetched. The Professor agrees but wonders if a new kind of hypnosis could somehow allow him to reach the deepest strata of the human mind and possibly unlock abilities never encountered before. Casting aside his initial skepticism, The Professor borrows stacks of books from the library and dives into an obsessive research on time, phenomenology, idealist philosophies and the nature of consciousness itself.

A few months go by and The Professor has developed a hypnosis chamber, encased in a Faraday cage, which implements a hybrid system blending sensory deprivation, neurostimulation and temporal cognition modulation. The Professor steps inside, completely naked, and puts on a helmet. As the door seals shut, a perfluorocarbon oxygen-rich liquid fills up the chamber, allowing liquid breathing. The helmet is activated, initiating a barrage of theta waves layered with customized tone sequences and fractal light patterns, which The Professor's calculations have shown could influence temporal perception. While the helmet is activated, The Professor tries to remember events from his past but the helmet shuts down after just a few minutes. Whilst going through the data collected, he finds that the helmet was activated for a total of 1 hour and 41 minutes, even though it seemed like he spent a much shorter time inside the chamber. Still, since nothing happened, The Professor discards his whole hypnosis endeavour as a waste of time, reaffirming his stance that the state theory of hypnosis is nothing more than pseudoscientific fantasy.

That night, The Professor experiences an extremely vivid dream: He finds himself floating in complete darkness, weightless and silent. Then, a blinding explosion erupts, resulting in the formation of a gargantuan sphere, swirling with multicolored clouds and shapes, and speckled with radiant white dots. As the kaleidoscopic sphere slowly expands, two other spheres, one white and one black, begin to bud off from the main sphere. The white sphere drifts to the left, the black to the right, and though they move apart, each remains tethered to the central parent sphere by a thick bundle of luminous fibers pulsating with energy. Despite sharing the same origin, the white and black spheres are not directly linked to each other.

After witnessing this event, The Professor is transported into a boundless void of darkness, referred to as **Void B**. Before his eyes stands a silver screen that begins to display a quick montage of his whole life, from his birth to his eventual death, even projecting events far into his future. He is able to psychically fast-forward or rewind

back at will but stops at a scene from his past, the moment he wishes his wife goodbye at a train station, before she departs on a business trip. Reaching toward the screen, his hand passes through it effortlessly, and he steps inside the screen, suddenly inhabiting the mind and body of his former self. He can feel everything: the warmth of his wife's embrace, the softness of the kiss she gave him right before stepping into the train, and even all his thoughts at that point in time. But then, he remembers what will happen. This was the last time he saw his wife. Her train would derail and she would die from her injuries. Desperate, he tries to speak to his past self to alter the outcome but quickly realizes nothing he does can change the past. He can relive any moment of his lifespan, feeling each and every emotion or thought and yet, he can neither control his past self nor change anything.

Back in Void B, The Professor tries to relive another moment but finds himself sinking into the ground, which has inexplicably become viscous. He screams for help, thrashing helplessly, until his whole body is completely submerged in a black liquid and violently ejected into **Void A**. There, he finds the editing machine and the screen. But when he walks towards it, he is again transported to someplace else, this time inside *The Golden Reverb*. The song "Blue Moon" echoes through the radio station whilst The Professor walks around, utterly baffled and disoriented. Then, as he walks through a dim hallway, he has a moment of epiphany. Suddenly, everything he has witnessed in this strange dream made sense. Something inexpressible has been unlocked in his mind but it's quickly followed by a wave of despair, causing him to wake up back to reality, in his bed, screaming his lungs out.

He tracks down the real-world location of *The Golden Reverb*, situated in a dilapidated and unpopulated ghetto within the city that had been ravaged by a storm. The radio station looks exactly like how it was in his dream, with the same song playing perpetually. He walks into a hallway and enters **Void A**. Guided by his earlier epiphany, he immediately seems to understand how to operate the editing machine. He uses it to display events of his life but strangely, unlike Void B, he can't view the future. Void A operates more or less like Void B with one key difference; here, **things can be changed** but **the future cannot be viewed**.

He uses the machine to generate a new version of his past, one where he stops his wife from boarding the doomed train, and inputs the scene into the timeline, referred to as **Linear Reality (LR)**. LR is reality as we know it, bound by the arrow of time. But as he skips forward from that point to observe the outcome of his change, his wife is still nowhere to be found. He rewinds back to the train station scene and stares in disbelief as she **STILL** boards the train. His edit has been **rejected**. The Professor becomes puzzled and increasingly frustrated. Any changes he makes to LR, even minor ones, are being rejected. So what's the point of the editing machine if past events can't be altered? Recalling his research, the answer to his problem becomes glaringly obvious: **memories**. Back to LR, transformed by his findings, The Professor is now a changed person. He becomes someone hell-bent on destroying the fatalistic nature of reality, resentful at how immutable the timeline is. Now, he is known as **The Hypnotist**. He purchases a remote castle, transferring all his research and equipment from his old lab, and begins the development of a memory altering machine.

In Void B, another version of The Professor stands before the silver screen, watching himself going through the chain of events that leads him to become The Hypnotist. But then, the screen abruptly cuts off and the

Hypnotist vanishes from the projection entirely, which means The Professor doesn't know about the castle where The Hypnotist is now located. Eyes wide with horror, he speaks to an unknown presence and shouts, "This is not what happens. His experiment fails!" Scenes from the future become fuzzier and lack coherence. Speaking to the invisible presence, he begs for **another duplicate** of him to be sent back to LR. He knows this goes against the "rules" but seeing how the eternalist nature of reality is being broken, now would be the perfect time to use the holes in the fabric of reality to stop the catastrophic **Syncfall** from coming to completion. This time, he wants his duplicate to be fully aware of **Time Empire** and everything that's been going on, a first in history. To aid him, he requests that the duplicate be provided with manpower. However, since new consciousness cannot be created from nothing, 5 empty vessels are assigned, each tethered to the duplicate's mind but incapable of independent thought. In the event that The Professor dies, they all cease to exist. These 5 men become **The Wardens**. The duplicate appears before The Professor, who simply says, "You know what to do." The duplicate nods solemnly and disappears into the darkness.

In The Professor's old laboratory, the same process that gave birth to The Detective occurs. Within pulsating lights, heartbeats and a swirling fog, the duplicate is forged from nothingness. His eyes snap open and standing around him are The Wardens, all 5 of them. Unlike The Detective, this duplicate is completed and perfectly healthy. He will assume the identity of The Professor in LR, determined to stop The Hypnotist at all cost.

Meanwhile, The Hypnotist goes to the train station in the early hours of the morning, whilst it's still empty. He scans the area methodically and finds a homeless man sleeping beside a trash container. Sensing a perfect candidate for his experiment, he checks the placement of CCTV cameras and confirms the man lies in a blindspot. He slips on a pair of gloves and lunges at him. They grapple on the floor but The Hypnotist quickly overpowers him and strangles him to death. He rises back on his feet and glances around to ensure there are no witnesses. He leaves the lifeless body behind and calmly exits the train station.

In Void A, he generates a new version of the homeless man's death, one in which he suffocates on spoiled food scavenged from the trash container. He then inputs the scene into LR, determined to erase his crime from reality itself. Back to LR, The Hypnotist stands before his now completed memory-altering machine. He puts on a helmet and activates the machine, which has been pre-programmed to erase the murder from his mind and replace it with a **false memory**. The machine maps the neutral engram of the original memory, which then enters a reconsolidation window. Electromagnetic stimulation disrupts targeted synapses linked to this memory (including any contextual and emotional relations associated with it), effectively erasing it. Afterwards, the machine embeds the false memory into a new engram while making sure the memory is correctly indexed to avoid any internal contradictions. When The Hypnotist regains consciousness, he finds a note left by his prior self: "If there has been a murder at the train station, you failed. One mind wasn't enough." The next day, he inspects the local newspapers and finds a small, easily overlooked, report stating that a homeless man was found strangled to death at the train station. Just then, the memories of what he has done resurfaces in his mind after a brutal headache, proving **his experiment failed**.

Over the following months, The Hypnotist shifts his attention towards surveillance efforts, taking particular interest in the Holloway Syndicate, whose members are known to be impulsive, violent and often irrational. Exploiting their recklessness, he taps into their cell phones, landlines, and even bugs their apartments. He knows these mobsters are much likelier to commit catastrophic mistakes such as botched deals, violent outbursts, or betrayals, that could lead them to prison, injury, or the death of themselves or their loved ones. In that case, participating in The Hypnotist's experiment would only serve their best interest. Luckily, **one of these mobsters is Mike Sullivan.**

One night, The Hypnotist picks up a ruckus through a bug planted at Apartment 101, Mike's residence. The audio crackles with sounds of shattered glass and broken furniture as Mike, clearly intoxicated and alone, rages through his apartment. Then, abruptly, the door slams shut, followed by silence. The Hypnotist stands right next to the speaker, patiently waiting for Mike's return. A few hours later, the door creaks open and Mike reenters, sobering and wailing in despair. The Hypnotist's eyes gleam with excitement; this could be it. Without wasting another second, he leaves the castle and drives towards Apartment 101.

There, he finds Mike slouching on the floor, gun in his hand, contemplating suicide as the magnitude of what he's done weighs down on him. He is visibly high, with his nose still dusted with cocaine residue. Dazed and shattered, Mike doesn't react to The Hypnotist's sudden presence. He's already made up his mind to end it all, consumed by the unthinkable thing he's just done. The Hypnotist kneels and calmly takes the gun from his hand, telling him he can still fix things. But when he admits he can't bring anyone back from the dead, Mike says there's no point in fixing anything if his crime is irreversible. The Hypnotist still maintains he can erase Mike's guilt, make it so even Mike himself will never know what he did, while someone else takes the fall. Mike, even high, remains skeptical but he knows there are only 2 options: submit to The Hypnotist's offer and whatever it entails or end his own life, knowing he will never be able to live with himself after what he did.

He begins to recount his story: In a **flashback**, 8 years ago, Lydia begins to question her life in organized crime and becomes allured by the idea of a fresh start, leaving everything behind and starting a new life, this time living earnestly. Her mental state gradually deteriorates due to the strain of constant fear, moral compromise, and the oppressive paranoia associated with the life she leads. Panic attacks become more frequent, while her antidepressants become less and less effective. One evening, after a missed period, she finds out she's pregnant. She pleads with Mike to leave the city with her and start over, for the sake of their child. But Mike flatly refuses. His work makes him feel alive and allows him to channel his sadistic impulses and inherent aggressivity for a purpose, offering a distorted form of **sublimation**. He suggests that Lydia gets an abortion but even if she still decides to keep the child, Mike's stance won't budge. He won't leave behind everything he's built, not for her, and not for a child.

That same night, angered by Mike's indifference and apathy, Lydia storms out of their apartment and drives to Frank's place. Frank has long harbored feelings for her but never acted on them, out of loyalty for his best friend. Still in her car, Lydia purposefully slams her head against the steering wheel and rushes to the door. She collapses in Frank's arms, sobbing, and falsely claims that Mike struck her. She knows Frank also expressed doubts about

staying in the organization and concludes he is her best shot for a way out. She paints Mike as abusive and violent, despite him never having laid a hand on her back then. Torn between his affection for Lydia and his loyalty to Mike, Frank is nevertheless horrified by what he believes happened and offers her a place to stay in his guest room. After taking a shower, Lydia enters Frank's bedroom and drops her bathrobe, seductively approaching him. His lust takes over and regardless of his friendship with Mike, he gives in. They make love and Lydia insists they don't use protection, intending to later make Frank believe that was the night Nora was conceived.

When Lydia asks for a divorce, Mike remains surprisingly indifferent. But when he discovers Frank's plans to marry her and raise their child as his own, he goes to confront him. Frank reiterates how much their friendship means to him but reminds Mike that he had feelings for Lydia long before Mike swept in and married her, despite being fully aware of Frank's affections for her. Frank did feel betrayed, which is the real reason he skipped their wedding, but he never held a grudge. He assures Mike that he and Lydia didn't become involved until the separation, which was the night she found out she was pregnant. Mike, though frustrated, expresses his best wishes to Frank and finally confesses that married life never suited him and the idea of having children never interested him. When Frank says he looks forward to raising "his" daughter, Mike suddenly realizes Frank has no idea he isn't Nora's biological father. Saying nothing of the truth, Mike gives Frank a vague warning to be wary of Lydia.

He then goes to confront Lydia, who admits she never told Frank the truth about Nora since it would only hurt him. Mike presses her to confess what tactics she employed to convince Frank to marry her, knowing very well he would never marry his best friend's ex without a valid reason as to why she couldn't return to Mike. Lydia smiles and wordlessly points to a small scar on her forehead. Horrified, Mike conceals his rage and silently leaves.

In the years following Frank's marriage to Lydia, the two friends become distant but on the few times they meet, their camaraderie resurfaces effortlessly, even if Lydia is never mentioned. Despite their differences, their bond remains unbreakable. But Mike's exacerbating loneliness and depression fester within him. 8 years after Nora's birth, Frank brings her for a trip to the seaside with Mike, who bonds easily with the girl as they play and swim together. As the trip ends and he bids her farewell, an unbearable mix of despair and envy overwhelms him. She could have been his. Frank's life could have been his. Days later, at a grand reception organized by the syndicate, Mike sees Frank, Nora and Lydia sharing joy and laughter at their table. Nora spots Mike and shouts, "Uncle Mike! Uncle Mike!", as she's about to run into his arms. But Lydia quickly intervenes, pulling her away without a word. This single gesture ignites the rage Mike has buried for years.

On the fateful night that would unravel everything, Mike snorts cocaine to placate his despair but this only serves to fuel his rage. He drives to Frank's house, where she confronts Lydia, demanding to know why she truly left him. She had claimed it was because he refused to leave the syndicate and yet, 8 years later, Frank and Lydia are both **still** highly active members. Lydia reveals that while Frank had promised to leave everything behind, the process of building new identities and basically restarting their lives proved more complicated and dangerous than anticipated, since they had to make sure the organization would never be able to track them down

afterwards. Once they started earning more, they both concluded it would be in their family's best interest to remain in the syndicate.

The irony of it all sends Mike's anger into overdrive. It's all been for nothing. Lydia left him and picked Frank to live a happy life with **his** daughter for a reason that proved to be meaningless. Lydia tries to reason with him, reminding Mike how disinterested he had been in their marriage and how he never wanted children. But Mike, simmering with anger, simply says, "People change." He throws himself at her and smacks her until she collapses on the floor, blood streaming down her face. As he stands over Lydia, he realizes that hurting her isn't enough. She took everything from him and now he needs to take everything from her. He breaks into Nora's room and hauls the terrified girl before her mother, who begs him to stop. But at that instant, Mike, in his drugged haze, buries the recent blissful memories he shared with Nora. The girl's tears and screams mean nothing to him. She isn't his daughter anymore, she's become a perfect instrument of vengeance. Without hesitation, he snaps her neck and Lydia, paralyzed with horror, can't even let out a scream. Mike then knocks her unconscious and leaves the house in a dissociative trance.

Back in Apartment 101, The Hypnotists say he will need Lydia's unconscious body for the experiment but insists that Frank must be eliminated to ensure its success. But Mike, with the effects of cocaine having subsided, refuses to murder his best friend even if he doesn't mind letting Frank take the fall for his crimes, so long as the guilt is removed from his mind forever. The Hypnotist complies but in that case, he will need to alter Frank's memory as well. Mike returns to the house, where Lydia is still unconscious on the floor. But Frank has already arrived, shaken and horrified by the scene before him. When Mike tries to subdue him, Frank pulls his weapon and in the violent struggle that follows, Mike accidentally pulls the trigger, killing Frank with a single bullet to the chest. Mike falls to his knees, eyes welling up with tears. After calming down and accepting what just happened, he drags Lydia's unconscious body to the trunk of his car and drives off into the night. On his way to The Hypnotist's castle, he notices an unknown vehicle tailing him. He outmaneuvers the car and forces it off road, crashing it into a wall. He draws his gun and approaches the wreckage where he finds a strange figure, one of The Wardens, unconscious inside. He looks for any communication devices and finds a mobile phone broken beyond repair. When he tries to peel off the black tissue on the man's face to unmask him, he realizes it's actually his skin. Baffled, he phones The Hypnotist who instructs him to bring The Warden to his castle.

Once there, The Hypnotist appears far more intrigued by The Warden's identity than dealing with Mike or Lydia. He plugs his unconscious body to the memory-altering machine and peers into The Warden's mind through the monitor. And what he finds makes perfect sense: Since The Warden is tethered to The Professor's mind, The Hypnotist uncovers everything. Time Empire has dispatched another duplicate of The Professor to rectify the **discontinuity** caused by The Hypnotist's forbidden ability to access Void A and edit LR. This explains why the Syncfall hasn't had any noticeable effect yet. Time Empire is still actively trying to correct the timeline by tasking The Professor's newest duplicate to eliminate The Hypnotist. The Hypnotist smiles when he realizes he doesn't have to modify his own memories anymore. The other duplicate is now supposed to assume The Professor's role in LR and thus, the influence of The Hypnotist's mind on reality is null since he is

no longer part of the official structure of reality. He turns to a confused Mike and simply says, “We won.” Immediately, he shoots The Warden, whose body shatters like glass, scattering across the floor.

Now, the experiment can begin. Mike and Lydia, still unconscious, are connected to the machine. Mike’s memory of the murders is erased and replaced with a benign false memory of him drinking himself to sleep on that night. Lydia’s recollection is overwritten with the fabricated version she would recount to The Detective in **Part 1**. In Void A, The Hypnotist inputs the altered events surrounding Frank’s and Nora’s death into LR. **The Hypnotist cannot view or modify events he has not personally witnessed.** He witnessed the murder of Nora and Frank through Mike’s and Lydia’s memories, which is why he is able to generate the modified **sequence of events**. In LR, The Hypnotist places an unconscious Mike in Apartment 101, where he will awaken with no memory of The Hypnotist or what truly transpired. Similarly, he puts Lydia’s unconscious body in her house and there, he finds Frank with multiple gunshot wounds on his chest, confirming that his modifications have been successfully integrated.

But then he notices a stitched scar on Frank’s forehead, as if his skull has been cut open and sealed again. Alarmed, he dashes out of the house only to be ambushed by The Wardens. A fierce shootout ensues and The Hypnotist narrowly manages to escape. When Lydia awakens, stunned and broken, she flees with Nora’s lifeless body to her mother’s village. That same night, unbeknownst to The Hypnotist, Mike sleepwalks, as if possessed, to *The Golden Reverb*. Meanwhile, in Apartment 101, The Detective’s incomplete creation occurs, as described in the **prologue**. By the time Mike sleepwalks back home, The Detective is long gone...

Part 3 - Frank Emerald

At the castle, The Hypnotist leans in towards The Detective and asks, “Now that you know everything, can I remove the mask?” Overwhelmed by anguish, self-loathing, and the crushing weight of these latest revelations, The Detective accepts. Beneath the mask, we find that The Detective is a disfigured **duplicate** of Mike. The Hypnotist explains that altering Mike’s memories inadvertently expedited his ability to transcend to Time Empire. **But since his memory has been altered, he was rejected.** At the precise moment of that rejection, the process of generating his duplicate, The Detective, was underway, resulting in an incomplete and malformed creation. The Hypnotist afterwards realized that **those who have become entangled, in one way or another, to Time Empire cannot have their memories altered.** This became obvious when he tried to erase The Detective’s memories to make him restart his investigation into Lydia’s and Nora’s disappearance.

The Detective asks why The Hypnotist even bothered hiring him to investigate this case, wouldn’t it have been easier if he was kept unaware? The Hypnotist surprisingly agrees but then recounts a night at a bar where his colleague and old friend, who happens to be The Detective’s therapist, drunkenly told him about a very peculiar patient of his, one who was amnesic and believed he was born from nothing. During his drunken ramblings, the therapist revealed that **the patient’s sole memory was breaking a girl’s porcelain doll in his childhood**, a memory The Hypnotist recognized as belonging to Mike. From that, he realized Mike’s duplicate had inexplicably manifested in Linear Reality. At first, he considered killing The Detective outright, fearing that if he recollects his true memories, his modifications of reality will become unstable and will be rejected. But then he

became intrigued by his existence. He wanted to understand if The Detective was simply a mistake from Time Empire or perhaps its solution... If it's the latter, eliminating The Detective will only provoke Time Empire into making another move to counter the Syncfall, just like it did by sending a second duplicate of The Professor. So The Hypnotist devised a plan to cement into The Detective's mind, with absolute certainty, that Frank killed Nora and Lydia killed Frank by having him uncover the case. This would stabilize his modifications and buy him enough time until the Syncfall reaches completion.

The Detective is still unable to grasp the significance of Time Empire (TE), Linear Reality (LR), the duplicates and the Syncfall. The Hypnotist explains TE and LR both follow different structures of time. TE is rooted in eternalism and the **B-theory of time**, where every event from the birth to the end of the universe already exists and individuals who can transcend into TE can experience every moment of their life non-linearly through Void B. He theorizes that TE may itself be sentient, considering it's capable of detecting threats and responding accordingly even if the extent of its responses are limited and weakened once the Syncfall is triggered. Contrary to his initial beliefs that TE is omnipotent, he found that it can be quite fallible and limited in its capabilities.

On the other hand, LR operates on the **growing block principle** where the future doesn't exist yet and new moments are added to reality through the passage of time. However there's a catch, LR is **entirely dependent** on TE. It has to follow the fatalistic nature of TE and each event must unfold exactly as it does in TE or there will be a **discontinuity**. Major discontinuities can be catastrophic and could trigger the **Syncfall**. Humans originally belong to LR but over millennia of evolution, some began to develop the ability to transcend into TE. To achieve this, the person sleepwalks to locations where TE and LR exist in superposition, such as *The Golden Reverb*, which then leads to Void B. When they do join Void B, TE sends a duplicate of them to LR to ensure no discontinuity. The **duplicates** normally have no awareness of TE but remain perfectly identical to their original counterpart, including all aspects of their consciousness (including memories). The memory of them sleepwalking to *The Golden Reverb* is vaguely recorded as a dream. In the case of a major discontinuity, Syncfall occurs, which is a gradual event that slowly kills TE, along with all the people who transcended into TE and their respective duplicates. This explains the strange pandemic plaguing the world. Once the Syncfall is in its final stages, weird temporal anomalies can occur, like the temporal jumps experienced by The Detective.

The Hypnotist initially believed the jumps were random but after inspecting The Detective's memories, he discovered patterns where certain jumps appeared deliberate and purposeful as if TE, in its dying state, was desperately trying to stop the Syncfall. Perhaps the jumps are manifestations of **Jung's synchronicity**, where events lacking causal connection seem meaningfully connected. Still, The Hypnotist doesn't quite understand why there are two conflicting structures of time at all. He speculates that when the universe was in its earliest stages, some primordial extra-dimensional God-like entities might have fought over the nature of reality, some championing linear causality, others eternalism. Even though TE ultimately prevailed, Void A and the editing machine still remained as relics of the war, powerful and forbidden to any beings. Since LR was too embedded in the fabrics of reality to be eliminated, it became bound to TE, forever serving as its subordinate.

The Hypnotist's self-hypnosis unintentionally granted him access to the editing machine in Void A, a breach TE never anticipated, leading to the beginning of the Syncfall. TE still tried to correct the discontinuity by sending a second duplicate of The Professor. But once The Hypnotist modified reality again and altered 2 minds (Mike's and Lydia's), the damage became irreversible. The Hypnotist, long resentful of the fatalistic nature of TE, did everything he could to break its grasp on reality. And finally, he won. It's only a matter of hours before the Syncfall is completed, with almost half of the global population already dead. In Void A, he can monitor the Syncfall's progress through a glowing status bar on the editing machine, creeping closer and closer to completion.

After regaining his memories of his past life as Mike, The Detective collapses into tears, loathing himself for who he was. Desperate to dissociate himself from his wicked past, he clings to the idea that his birth produced someone new, that he isn't Mike. But The Hypnotist retorts by explaining that the only thing differentiating The Detective and Mike are memories. Even if memories and identity are intrinsically linked, they aren't the only factor defining someone. Now that he regained them, he IS Mike, as evidenced by their brutal fusion earlier. He asks The Detective to accept who he really is, saying he and Mike form part of the same whole, like the **shadow** and **persona** being aspects of the same self. Even the diachronic problem of personal identity offers no escape to this certainty. The Detective's guilt and regrets fester. Not only did he murder Nora and Frank but he is also responsible for the deaths of billions of people. Another tortured scream echoes from the nearby room and The Hypnotist reveals it comes from The Professor, who has been captured and is now in the final stages of the disease. He used him to locate Lydia by peering into his memories. He keeps him alive until the Syncfall is completed, to make sure TE's death won't affect him since according to reality, The Professor is the legitimate duplicate and The Hypnotist is an anomaly who shouldn't even be here by now. Once the Syncfall is completed, he will put The Detective out of his misery but not before ensuring TE's death is final such that it will no longer attempt to rectify the timeline. Now alone in this large living room, The Detective crumples into hopelessness. Then, he senses something approaching from behind.

He turns his gaze and is stunned to see **The Professor**, who's now even more disgustingly deformed by the disease. The Professor silently motions for him to stay quiet as he unlocks The Detective's restraints with a small key. This doesn't make any sense. He can hear both The Hypnotist and The Professor shouting in the nearby room so who is this doppelganger? Another duplicate? Once The Detective is freed, The Professor hands him a different key and whispers, "Free me, and let me do it." He then slips behind a wall and vanishes into the shadows. Moments later, The Hypnotist rejoins The Detective, eyes gleaming triumphantly. Just then, The Detective, now free, lunges at him and violently knocks him to the ground. He races to the adjacent room where The Professor is being kept chained to a wall. He unlocks the restraints and The Professor tackles The Hypnotist and slams him down. As yellowish mucus dribbles from his mouth into The Hypnotist's face, The Professor gouges his eyes out and obliterates his skull into pieces with his bare hands. The Detective gazes at the scene in both disgust and satisfaction, now that the cause of so much suffering is no more.

As The Professor rises from The Hypnotist's headless corpse, he turns to The Detective and asks, "Who freed you?" Still dazed by what just happened, he replies, "You did." The Professor seems to immediately understand

that a temporal jump is imminent and asks The Detective to promptly leave. When The Detective asks what's going to happen now that The Hypnotist is dead, The Professor ambiguously replies, "Now, Time Empire will make things right."

While driving aimlessly along a deserted road, The Detective is struck by a pounding headache. He starts retching violently and spews out a large amount of blood and organic matter. As the pain intensifies, his car veers off road and stops. He exits the vehicle whilst his skin begins to bulge and stretch grotesquely as if something within him is clawing to get out. Screaming in extreme agony, he feels his bones snapping and shattering. Finally, his skull splits open down the middle and two hands emerge from the gap, tearing The Detective's body apart from the inside. The rest of his body is bisected vertically, with his intestines and shredded organs spilling on the dirt. From The Detective's mangled remains, a naked man rises, trembling and gasping for air. The man is none other than **Frank Emerald**. Confused and disoriented, Frank trudges to the car and drives off into the night.

At dawn, Frank reaches his house and inside, he is confronted with a most nightmarish sight: Lydia lies beaten and unconscious whilst Nora is unmistakably dead, her body cold and lifeless. He quickly dresses and calls the paramedics. Once they arrive, Lydia slowly regains consciousness. With a weak and broken voice, she murmurs, "Mike did this." Frank, fuming with rage, grabs a gun and dashes to Apartment 101. But there, he finds Mike on the floor, with a bullet wound in his head. Unable to deal with the crushing guilt, he has shot himself. Frank silently stares at the corpse of the man who was once his closest friend, feeling lost and empty. He knows there's a huge gap in his memories but he can't explain why. As the weight of Nora's death finally crashes down on him, he begins to cry, mourning for everything he has lost.

Later that day, still shaken and searching for meaning, Frank drives to *The Golden Reverb*, drawn to it by a strange sense of familiarity. He walks to its entrance but can't bring himself to step inside. From where he stands, he can faintly hear the song "Blue Moon" playing from within. Hearing footsteps, he turns and finds The Professor right behind him, who is now a perfectly healthy man. The Professor introduces himself and gently asks what Frank remembers. From Frank's perspective, he just remembers kissing his wife and daughter goodbye the previous day. Everything afterwards is a complete void up to the moment he inexplicably woke up next to a deserted road, beside a car that wasn't his. But he does recall a strange dream of being inside Void B, where he could freely experience any moments of his life, past, present and future. In the dream, he did briefly glimpse a future where Nora isn't there.

The Professor tells him about the existence of Time Empire and fills the gaps in his memories. He promises that once he enters Void B, he will be able to relieve his past with Nora although her death can't be erased. Fate is regrettably inescapable and the timeline remains immutable. However, transcending into TE comes at a cost: one cannot return to Linear Reality. The Professor reveals Frank unknowingly began to develop the ability to transcend and this emerging power allowed him to preserve his true memories deep inside his unconscious, thus protecting it from The Hypnotist's attempts to alter reality. The Hypnotist has now been completely erased from the timeline, as if he never even existed. It's this absolute certainty of the real, buried deep inside Frank's

consciousness, which once saved Time Empire and the entire fabric of reality. Now, the pandemic never happened and the billions who died are now still alive. Before parting ways with Frank, The Professor says TE did him a favor. Unlike others, who sleepwalk when transitioning and have no awareness of TE beforehand, Frank can choose when exactly he wants to transcend to TE.

Epilogue

A few years later, Frank and Lydia still share a quiet life while the grief of losing Nora still lingers. One night, Frank sees Lydia sleepwalking out of the house. He follows her through the silent streets until she reaches *The Golden Reverb*. Once she disappears inside, he smiles softly and whispers, “Let’s go back to her, my love.” Just then, a strange memory flashes in his mind, **one where he mischievously breaks the porcelain doll of a little girl**. Though confused by its origin, he shrugs it off. He glances back at the city as a final goodbye to reality as he knows it and walks into the radio station, excited to reunite with his family beyond the arrow of time.

The End